3

Rose

Carrying the sketchbook under her arm, Rose shaded her eyes with her hand as she walked by the canal that ran along the edge of the Loire on her way to Quai du Roi.

She hadn't been this far east of Orléans since before her mother got sick. She, Léa and Maman would often come to this part of the river on weekends, lifting their skirts to tuck the ends in at their waists and removing their shoes to wade into the shallow water and onto the sandbars. Holding narrow fishing poles, they'd muddy the water with their feet to attract *goujons*—the tiny whitebait no bigger than her thumb. They'd spend an entire afternoon filling a bucket with the fish that their mother would later dip in milk and flour, then deep-fry in oil, serving it with fresh lemon squeezed on top and homemade *frites*. It was a favorite childhood memory, which made Rose's mouth water.

By the time she reached Quai du Roi, the noises from the trams and buses in the center of Orléans had receded into a distant hum. Sunlight shimmered on the sandy riverbed, making the water sparkle.

André, seated on a bench along the embankment, saw her and smiled, waving at her to join him.

"I'm glad you came. Sorry about having to rush off yesterday."

"Was it because of the gendarmes?"

He shrugged. "No one wants to be around those guys."

Rose didn't press him.

Pointing at the sketchbook on her lap, he said, "We have that in common."

"We do?" She edged a little closer to him. "Tell me what you draw."